

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Sales and Business Development English



Teacher's guide

Teach practical workplace communication with specific cases, clear language targets, and a repeatable feedback process.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For account executives, business-development representatives, sales managers, partnership teams, solutions consultants, channel managers, and revenue leaders.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Your course at a glance

Use the lesson numbers to match this document with the website and the other guides.

01 Discovery and Qualification

Clarify missing information before responding.

02 Value Proposition and Use-Case Fit

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

03 Objection Handling and Competitive Pressure

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

04 Pricing, Discounting, and Approval

Negotiate scope or timing while making conditions explicit.

05 Enterprise Buying Committees

Clarify missing information before responding.

06 Negotiation and Contract Redlines

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

07 Partnerships and Channel Development

Negotiate scope or timing while making conditions explicit.

08 CRM Hygiene and Pipeline Reviews

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

Choose your pace

Quick practice: spend 15 minutes reading one conversation and rehearsing one scenario. Full lesson: allow 45-60 minutes for language work, three conversations, two speaking scenarios, and feedback.

Level support

B1 learners can use the frames and a partner. B2 learners can try a response before reading the model. C1 learners can add the harder follow-up and reduce preparation time. These are teaching suggestions, not certified CEFR level ratings.

After practicing: open the AI prompt workshop, or use the prompts at the end of this guide.

A 60-minute lesson that works

Prepare the case and the learner pages. Keep the model response hidden until learners have attempted their own. Choose two field terms that are important to understanding the case.

0-5 minutes | Activate experience

Ask learners to name a comparable situation without sharing confidential details. Introduce the communication goal.

5-12 minutes | Read and sort facts

Read the case. Learners identify confirmed facts, unknowns, the audience, and the immediate communication need.

12-22 minutes | Notice and practice language

Explain the workshop pattern. Work through the vocabulary and editing example, then discuss both language checks and the reasons behind the choices.

22-35 minutes | 05 • Conversations

Read one ten-turn conversation aloud, notice a useful expression, then compare the other two. Identify each speaker's purpose and how the exchange ends.

35-47 minutes | 06 • Say it

Rehearse both speaking scenarios from the workbook. Give two minutes of preparation, switch roles, and use the success checks. Add the complication only after a successful first round.

47-55 minutes | Compare and revise

Reveal the model. Discuss alternative acceptable wording. Give one meaning correction and one language correction, then repeat.

55-60 minutes | Retrieve and transfer

Close the materials. Learners recall two expressions and identify one communication habit to use in another situation.

Adapt the session

For 45 minutes, study one complete conversation and rehearse one scenario; assign the others for oral follow-up. For 90 minutes, rehearse all three conversations and give both scenarios a second round. More time should produce more meaningful practice, not longer explanations.

LESSON 01 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Discovery and Qualification

Clarify missing information before responding.

CASE

A prospect asks for a demonstration but has not explained the current workflow, problem, or buying process.

Teach this move

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Vocabulary to check: discovery, qualification, pain point, buying process.

Model response

What are you trying to improve in the current workflow? Could we understand the problem and who will evaluate the solution? That will help us make the demonstration relevant to your decision.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. After an introductory phrase such as 'Could you explain', the embedded question uses statement word order: "what this means".

Second-round challenge

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Language-check answers

1. B - Could you confirm when the review starts? The embedded question uses subject then verb: "the review starts".
2. A - Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review? This question distinguishes two meanings of 'ready' that affect the next action.

05 • Conversations

1. A demonstration needs a workflow - The lesson's prospect requests a demonstration without explaining the workflow, problem, or buying process.
2. A replacement request with an unclear trigger - Separate fictional case: a prospect asks about replacing a scheduling system, but has not said whether the concern is cost, usability, or a contract event.

3. A trial request from outside the user team - Separate fictional case: an innovation manager requests a trial for a warehouse workflow, but the warehouse owner has not participated in discovery.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A quote request from an unknown buying role

A fictional prospect's analyst requests pricing for fifty users but has not explained the workflow, user group, or purchasing role. Hold a short discovery conversation that clarifies purpose without treating the analyst as the budget owner.

Role A: You are the account executive. Ask what the pricing will support and which workflow is in scope.

Role B: You are the prospect's analyst. Explain that you are gathering information and must confirm the user group internally.

Possible opening: Could you clarify what decision the fifty-user estimate will support and which team would use the service?

Success checks

- Distinguish an exploratory estimate from a qualified purchase.
- Clarify workflow and the contact's role without assumptions.
- Agree a focused next discovery step with unknowns recorded.

Add a complication: Your sales colleague wants to mark the opportunity qualified because a user count was supplied.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 02 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Value Proposition and Use-Case Fit

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

CASE

A sales slide lists product features, but the prospect wants to reduce time spent preparing monthly reports.

Teach this move

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

Vocabulary to check: value proposition, use case, success metric, stakeholder.

Model response

The relevant question is how the product supports your reporting workflow. I'll connect the demonstration to that task and show what would need to be tested before we claim a time saving.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised sentence names the action in familiar words. Specialist vocabulary is useful when it adds precision, but repeating abstract nouns can hide the meaning.

Second-round challenge

Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Language-check answers

1. A - The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed. This gives the meaning in familiar words.
2. C - How would you describe the next step in your own words? An open request lets the listener show their understanding.

05 • Conversations

1. Features are not the prospect's outcome - The lesson's prospect wants less time spent preparing monthly reports, but the sales slide lists features.
2. A notification is not a resolved approval - Separate fictional case: a prospect wants fewer delayed approvals; a demonstration shows automatic notifications, but no outcome test has occurred.

3. One export button, several reporting responsibilities - Separate fictional case: a sales demo shows a one-click export; the prospect's reporting workflow also requires review and reconciliation, which have not been assessed.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Search results versus successful retrieval

A fictional prospect wants staff to find the correct procedure faster. A demonstration returns many search results, but no users have been tested for finding the correct current document. Explain the capability-outcome distinction and agree a success question.

Role A: You are the solutions consultant. Explain why result count is not the desired business outcome.

Role B: You are the prospect's service lead. Define the need as finding the correct current procedure, with timing still unmeasured.

Possible opening: Returning many results is a search capability; your outcome is finding the correct current procedure efficiently.

Success checks

- Distinguish product output from the prospect's intended outcome.
- Avoid claiming unmeasured accuracy or time savings.
- Agree a relevant success metric and stakeholder test.

Add a complication: A colleague wants to call a larger result list better performance.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 03 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Objection Handling and Competitive Pressure

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

CASE

A prospect says a competitor is cheaper, but the quotes include different service levels and implementation support.

Teach this move

Use the same time period, scope, and measurement basis for both options. Explain a difference with 'whereas' or 'while'. State what improves and what is given up; do not hide the weaker side of a recommendation.

Vocabulary to check: objection, competitor, differentiator, total cost.

Model response

Could we compare the same scope and support assumptions? The quoted prices cover different packages. That will help us discuss total cost and fit without dismissing the other option.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. 'Better' already has comparative meaning, so it does not need 'more'. Naming the criterion and tradeoff makes the comparison useful.

Second-round challenge

Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

Language-check answers

1. C - Option A is faster, whereas option B costs less. 'Whereas' marks a contrast between two options.
2. B - An increase of one percentage point. Subtracting 6% from 7% gives one percentage point. The relative increase is about 16.7%.

05 • Conversations

1. Cheaper quotes with different support - The lesson's prospect compares a lower-priced competitor quote with a proposal containing different service levels and implementation support.

2. Lower entry fee, unconfirmed overage costs - Separate fictional case: a prospect compares two software offers for the same year; one has a lower base fee but its usage overage terms are not supplied.

3. A faster launch with more client preparation - Separate fictional case: offer A states a two-week setup assuming client-prepared data; offer B states four weeks and includes data preparation. Data readiness is unconfirmed.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A free pilot with different exit work

A fictional competitor offers a free pilot, while another proposal charges for setup. The competitor's data-export and exit-support terms are unknown, as are the prospect's likely exit needs. Compare the offers without implying that free means either best or deceptive.

Role A: You are the account executive. Ask for equivalent pilot scope and exit terms.

Role B: You are the prospect's evaluation lead. Explain what the pilot must test and what an orderly exit would require.

Possible opening: The pilot fee is one comparison point; could we also check setup responsibilities and exit support for both offers?

Success checks

- Use verified scope and pricing only.
- Treat missing competitor terms as unknown rather than unfavorable facts.
- Agree a consistent pilot and exit comparison.

Add a complication: A salesperson wants to invent hidden competitor fees to overcome the objection.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 04 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Pricing, Discounting, and Approval

Negotiate scope or timing while making conditions explicit.

CASE

A customer requests a 15% discount. The salesperson can discuss options but does not have authority to approve that reduction.

Teach this move

Acknowledge the goal and explain the available choices. Connect an offer to its actual conditions. A useful response makes room for discussion without promising approval or resources you do not control.

Vocabulary to check: discount, procurement, margin, approval path.

Model response

I can take the request through our approval process. Could we clarify the scope and commercial terms you are proposing? I do not want to promise a discount before it is authorized.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. For an ordinary future condition, the "if" clause uses present tense. The other clause can express the future consequence or possibility.

Second-round challenge

The preferred option is unavailable. Offer an alternative and clearly state any approval still needed.

Language-check answers

1. B - If the scope changes, we will review the schedule. The "if" clause uses present tense; the main clause states the future response.
2. A - We can assess the addition and explain its effect on the agreed scope. This offers a useful next step while keeping the approval and scope question open.

05 · Conversations

1. A fifteen-percent request needs approval - Separate fictional extension of the lesson: the customer requests a 15% discount on a proposal covering core setup and two onsite workshops. The salesperson cannot approve it. Remote workshops are an alternative to assess, but revised pricing and delivery approval remain pending.

2. A smaller first phase instead of an unapproved discount - Separate fictional case: a customer needs service for thirty users but asks whether starting with ten could reduce the initial commitment; pricing for the smaller scope is not approved.

3. A payment-term request with no authority to concede - Separate fictional case: a buyer requests a longer payment period in place of a discount; the salesperson has not obtained finance approval for either change.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A discount tied to an unconfirmed reference call

A fictional customer offers to provide a reference call in exchange for a discount. Neither the customer's reference permission nor the supplier's discount approval is confirmed. Discuss the proposal without treating either side's offer as authorized.

Role A: You are the salesperson. Explain the required commercial review and ask about reference approval.

Role B: You are the customer contact. Clarify that you must obtain internal permission before offering a reference.

Possible opening: We can discuss the proposal, but both the discount and the reference participation need the appropriate approvals.

Success checks

- Keep both approvals explicitly pending.
- Describe the proposed exchange without promising acceptance.
- Agree who confirms each condition before terms change.

Add a complication: A colleague wants to record the reference as committed to justify the discount request.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 05 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Enterprise Buying Committees

Clarify missing information before responding.

CASE

A contact is enthusiastic about a proposal but has not explained who controls the budget or approves the purchase.

Teach this move

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Vocabulary to check: champion, economic buyer, buying committee, forecast category.

Model response

Who else needs to evaluate the proposal, and how is the budget approved? I'd like to understand the decision process so we can provide the right information to each participant.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. After an introductory phrase such as 'Could you explain', the embedded question uses statement word order: "what this means".

Second-round challenge

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Language-check answers

1. A - Could you confirm when the review starts? The embedded question uses subject then verb: "the review starts".
2. C - Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review? This question distinguishes two meanings of 'ready' that affect the next action.

05 • Conversations

1. An enthusiastic contact is not a confirmed economic buyer - The lesson's contact supports the proposal but has not identified budget control or purchase approval responsibilities.
2. Technical approval leaves budget authority unresolved - Separate fictional case: a prospect's IT reviewer has found no technical objection, but budget ownership and procurement approval are unconfirmed.

3. A champion changes roles before the decision - Separate fictional case: an internal champion moves to another department; the successor's interest and budget authority have not been confirmed.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Branch and parent-company approval roles are unclear

A fictional branch contact wants to buy a service, but says the parent company may control software spending. Neither party's approval role is confirmed. Clarify the buying committee without guessing from organizational seniority.

Role A: You are the account executive. Ask who owns the budget and which approvals apply to this purchase.

Role B: You are the branch operations contact. Explain the uncertainty and identify the internal person who can clarify it.

Possible opening: Could you confirm whether this purchase is decided at the branch or requires parent-company approval?

Success checks

- Separate job title from confirmed purchase authority.
- Identify the unresolved budget and approval questions.
- Agree a clarification contact before changing the forecast category.

Add a complication: A salesperson assumes the branch director can approve everything because of their title.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 06 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Negotiation and Contract Redlines

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

CASE

A customer returns contract wording on liability and asks the salesperson to accept it immediately.

Teach this move

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Vocabulary to check: redline, liability, indemnity, commercial term.

Model response

I'll send the proposed wording to the appropriate legal and commercial reviewers. Could you explain the business concern behind the change so they can assess it in context?

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision names the document and requested response. It avoids expressions that may be unfamiliar or ambiguous for an international audience.

Second-round challenge

The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Language-check answers

1. C - Send it no later than Thursday. 'By' sets the latest point, while 'after' refers to a later time.
2. B - Could you confirm the document version needed for the review? The requested action and information are explicit.

05 • Conversations

1. Route the liability redline for authorized review - The lesson's customer returns liability wording and requests immediate acceptance from the salesperson.
2. Two contract versions in the negotiation - Separate fictional case: a buyer's email refers to version four, but its attachment is version three; the salesperson has no confirmed final redline.

3. A commercial request mixed with an indemnity change - Separate fictional case: a customer returns a proposal requesting quarterly billing and revised indemnity wording; neither change has been approved by the supplier.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | An unmarked replacement clause

A fictional customer pastes a replacement contract paragraph into an email without identifying the original clause or document version. The salesperson cannot assess its legal effect. Request a reviewable redline and realistic routing information.

Role A: You are the salesperson. Ask for the document version, clause reference, and marked change.

Role B: You are the customer's contract coordinator. Clarify what you can supply and when you can confirm availability.

Possible opening: Could you send the replacement wording against the intended contract version so our reviewer can assess the change?

Success checks

- Request a specific reviewable document and clause reference.
- Avoid interpreting or accepting legal wording without authority.
- Agree routing and a realistic timing check rather than a guaranteed approval.

Add a complication: The customer asks you to reply accepted before supplying the missing context.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 07 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Partnerships and Channel Development

Negotiate scope or timing while making conditions explicit.

CASE

A potential channel partner requests exclusivity but has not specified territory, activities, or expected contribution.

Teach this move

Acknowledge the goal and explain the available choices. Connect an offer to its actual conditions. A useful response makes room for discussion without promising approval or resources you do not control.

Vocabulary to check: channel partner, exclusivity, pipeline, enablement.

Model response

Could we define the territory, responsibilities, and expected contribution first? Those details are necessary for the team to evaluate whether an exclusive arrangement would make sense.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. For an ordinary future condition, the "if" clause uses present tense. The other clause can express the future consequence or possibility.

Second-round challenge

The preferred option is unavailable. Offer an alternative and clearly state any approval still needed.

Language-check answers

1. B - If the scope changes, we will review the schedule. The "if" clause uses present tense; the main clause states the future response.
2. A - We can assess the addition and explain its effect on the agreed scope. This offers a useful next step while keeping the approval and scope question open.

05 · Conversations

1. Exclusivity needs a defined scope - The lesson's potential channel partner requests exclusivity without specifying territory, activities, or expected contribution.
2. Training support before a reseller launch - Separate fictional case: a prospective reseller requests product training for twenty staff before signing an agreement; training capacity and commercial terms are not confirmed.

3. A shared lead needs agreed responsibilities - Separate fictional case: two potential partners discuss a jointly identified prospect; neither has agreed customer-contact ownership or pipeline attribution.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A partner requests a guaranteed lead quota

A fictional prospective channel partner asks for ten qualified leads per month in return for attending enablement sessions. No lead volume is forecast or approved. Discuss a bounded alternative without guaranteeing pipeline.

Role A: You are the channel manager. Explain that training participation does not establish a guaranteed lead allocation.

Role B: You are the prospective partner lead. Explore a reviewable activity plan and how progress might be assessed.

Possible opening: We can discuss an activity plan, but we cannot treat ten qualified leads per month as a confirmed commitment.

Success checks

- Keep unverified lead volume out of commitments.
- Negotiate concrete activities and review conditions.
- Distinguish a proposed arrangement from an approved public announcement.

Add a complication: The partner wants the guarantee included in a launch announcement before agreement.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 08 / FACILITATOR NOTES

CRM Hygiene and Pipeline Reviews

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

CASE

A deal is forecast to close this month, but procurement has not started and the customer has given no confirmed date.

Teach this move

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Vocabulary to check: CRM, pipeline, close date, commit, slippage.

Model response

The current close date is an assumption. Procurement has not started, and the customer has not confirmed timing. I'll update the forecast explanation and identify the next evidence needed.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

Second-round challenge

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Language-check answers

1. A - The change may have contributed to the delay. 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.
2. C - In this pilot, the observed result was ... This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

05 · Conversations

1. A close date without customer confirmation - The lesson's deal is forecast to close this month, but procurement has not begun and the customer has given no confirmed date.
2. A verbal preference is not a signed order - Separate fictional case: a prospect says the supplier is its preferred option, but contract review and signature authority remain unconfirmed.

3. Two records may describe one opportunity - Separate fictional case: a CRM pipeline contains two records for the same prospect discussion, each with the same proposed value; ownership and duplication have not yet been reconciled.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A procurement meeting was rescheduled

A fictional prospect moved its procurement meeting from this week to next week. The deal's close date was never confirmed by the customer. Discuss the forecast impact without assuming either inevitable slippage or no effect.

Role A: You are the account executive. State the meeting change and the unconfirmed close date.

Role B: You are the sales manager. Ask which dependencies need checking before revising the forecast.

Possible opening: The procurement meeting moved to next week, but we still do not have a customer-confirmed close date.

Success checks

- Separate a scheduled meeting from a purchase commitment.
- Explain possible timing impact without presenting it as certain.
- Agree the customer clarification needed for the forecast update.

Add a complication: A colleague wants to call the deal guaranteed for this month because the meeting remains on the calendar.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the next two prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Writing feedback begins with your draft. Vocabulary, grammar and review prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has eight practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

The two starter prompts use B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-28. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Adapt a partner or class activity

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Sales and Business Development English

Professional audience: account executives, business-development representatives, sales managers, partnership teams, solutions consultants, channel managers, and revenue leaders

Scope: All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Lesson 01: Discovery and Qualification

Original fictional case: A prospect asks for a demonstration but has not explained the current workflow, problem, or buying process.

Language workshop: Ask a precise question

Communication goal: Clarify missing information before responding.

Language guidance: Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): When you say ..., do you mean ...? / Could you clarify which ...? / So, my understanding is Is that right?

Vocabulary: discovery: The process of learning needs or facts; in litigation, formal exchange of relevant information. / qualification: Documented demonstration that an item, process, or person meets defined requirements for a purpose. / pain point: A specific difficulty experienced by a customer or user. / buying process: The steps an organization follows to evaluate, approve, and make a purchase.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Writing task: Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Optional second-round challenge: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: What are you trying to improve in the current workflow? Could we understand the problem and who will evaluate the solution? That will help us make the demonstration relevant to your decision.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Adapt this material for a teaching session

1. Ask me one brief planning question covering learner support needs, group size and available time. Offer a default of two B2 learners and 20 minutes. Stop and wait; use the default only if I choose it.
2. Create a timed plan using the supplied case or dialogue, its actual terminology and one narrow language goal. Include an individual first attempt, partner exchange, focused feedback and a retry. Keep the total within the time I choose. State what the learner should be able to communicate at the end.
3. Provide separate role cards for two or three professional speakers. Each card needs an objective, known information and one question to resolve. Label any invented private information as a variation; do not contradict shared facts. Do not place the model answer on the learner cards.
4. Add a B1 support option with useful frames, a B2 independent task and a C1 extension involving a plausible competing constraint. Maintain the same professional meaning across levels. Explain unfamiliar terms without removing the field's normal language. Include a workable solo alternative.
5. Put teacher notes and suggested responses in a clearly separate section after the learner material. Include likely misunderstandings and a short observation checklist for facts, clarity, tone and next step. Accept multiple successful formulations. Finish with one exit question and a delayed-recall task; identify what the teacher should check before use.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level

Adjust tone and register

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Sales and Business Development English

Professional audience: account executives, business-development representatives, sales managers, partnership teams, solutions consultants, channel managers, and revenue leaders

Scope: All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Lesson 01: Discovery and Qualification

Original fictional case: A prospect asks for a demonstration but has not explained the current workflow, problem, or buying process.

Language workshop: Ask a precise question

Communication goal: Clarify missing information before responding.

Language guidance: Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): When you say ..., do you mean ...? / Could you clarify which ...? / So, my understanding is Is that right?

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END REFERENCE

TASK: Match the language to the listener

1. Choose a short message or utterance from the reference and quote it exactly. Identify its purpose and likely audience. Ask me to choose a new audience: a close colleague, a decision-maker, or an external reader who may not know the jargon. Stop and wait.
2. Ask me to adapt that message for the chosen reader, keeping its facts and degree of certainty unchanged. Offer a short frame only if I request help. Wait for my attempt before showing alternatives.
3. Discuss at most three choices in my version: directness, specialist vocabulary and interpersonal tone. Explain when a direct request is clearer than extra politeness, and when an unfamiliar abbreviation needs expansion. Avoid cultural stereotypes or claims that one nationality always communicates a certain way.
4. Show two natural alternatives, such as a concise spoken version and a more explicit written version. Explain the tradeoff in each. Do not turn a request into an order, a possibility into a promise, or a pending decision into approval.
5. Ask me to respond to one realistic follow-up from the new reader, then wait. Finish by asking me to adapt the message for a second audience without losing its core meaning. Give feedback only after the attempt.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level